Kathmandu University
Department of Computer Science and Engineering
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A Project Report
on
"Evaluation of Ethical Responsibilities: IOE Data Breach"

[Code No.: COMP 343]

(For partial fulfillment of Year III / Semester II in Computer Science)

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January 14, 2026

Bona fide Certificate

This project work on

“Evaluation of Ethical Responsibilities: IOE Data Breach”

is the bona fide work of

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who carried out the project work under my supervision.

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Declaration

We, the undersigned students, hereby declare that this project report entitled "Evaluation of Ethical Responsibilities : IOE Data Breach", submitted in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the course COMP 343 (3rd Year / 2nd Semester, Department of Computer Science and Engineering, Kathmandu University), is our original work carried out under the supervision of Mr. Hempal Shrestha. This work has not been submitted, either in part or in full, for any other degree or diploma at this university or any other institution. We have acknowledged all sources of information used in this report and have cited them properly. We take full responsibility for the content, analysis, review, and conclusions presented herein. Any plagiarism or misrepresentation detected shall be our sole responsibility.

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Abstract

The increasing reliance of academic institutions on digital information systems has significantly amplified ethical responsibilities related to data protection and privacy. On 3 February 2025, the Institute of Engineering (IOE), Tribhuvan University, experienced a large-scale data breach that exposed sensitive personal information of approximately 7,400 students across multiple campuses. This incident revealed not only technical vulnerabilities but also profound ethical shortcomings in institutional accountability, transparency, and professional responsibility.

This study presents an ethical case analysis of the IOE data breach by examining the background and causes of the incident, the technical factors that enabled it, and the ethical implications arising from the institutional response. A qualitative methodology was adopted, utilizing interviews, media reports, professional commentary, and legal documents to assess ethical compliance against established professional codes and Nepal's legal framework.

The findings indicate systemic failures in cybersecurity governance, delayed disclosure to affected individuals, and insufficient harm mitigation. The study concludes that ethical responsibility in cybersecurity extends beyond technical competence and requires proactive governance, transparency, and respect for stakeholder rights. Recommendations are proposed to strengthen ethical data governance in Nepalese academic institutions.

Keywords: Data Breach, Ethics, Cybersecurity, Academic Institutions, Privacy, Nepal

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Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 Background

With the increasing digitization of academic and administrative processes, educational institutions now rely heavily on information systems to store and manage sensitive personal data such as student records, examination details, contact information, and financial data. While this digital transformation has improved efficiency and accessibility, it has also exposed institutions to significant cybersecurity and ethical risks if proper safeguards are not in place.

On 3 February 2025, the Institute of Engineering (IOE), Tribhuvan University, experienced a major data breach in which the personal information of approximately 7,400 students from multiple constituent and affiliated campuses was exposed. The compromised data reportedly included names, addresses, dates of birth, phone numbers, and other sensitive personal details. Parts of the leaked data were later advertised for sale on the dark web, confirming the severity of the incident. The breach revealed serious weaknesses in IOE's data protection practices, including outdated infrastructure, weak access controls, lack of encryption, and insufficient security monitoring. The delayed institutional response further increased the potential risks faced by students, such as identity theft, phishing attacks, and misuse of personal information. Beyond its immediate consequences, the incident drew attention to broader questions concerning privacy, responsibility, and institutional accountability.

Given that IOE is Nepal's leading engineering institution and a center for computer science and cybersecurity education, the breach exposed a troubling gap between academic knowledge and real-world implementation. This incident therefore serves as a critical case for examining the ethical responsibilities of IT professionals and institutions in safeguarding sensitive information.

1.2 Context and Ethical Background

In modern academic environments, personal data has become an essential operational resource. Student enrollment, examination systems, identity verification, and administrative coordination all depend on the collection and processing of sensitive personal information. Students are required to submit such data as a condition of participation in academic life, leaving them with limited ability to refuse, negotiate,

or meaningfully consent. This structural imbalance creates a relationship of trust in which institutions assume a heightened ethical responsibility to protect the interests and dignity of students.

The data breach at the Institute of Engineering (IOE) must therefore be understood not merely as an operational failure but as an ethical event. When an institution entrusted with personal data fails to protect it or respond responsibly after a failure, the resulting harm extends beyond data exposure. It affects student autonomy, psychological security, and trust in institutional authority.

1.3 Why This Incident is an Ethical Issue

Ethical responsibility does not begin at the moment of failure; it exists from the moment data is collected. Institutions that gather personal information implicitly promise to safeguard it and to act in the best interest of data subjects. When this promise is broken, ethical questions arise regardless of whether legal consequences follow.

In the IOE case, the ethical concern is intensified by the institution's academic role. As a leading engineering institution responsible for educating future professionals, IOE is expected to embody ethical standards in practice. The apparent disconnect between ethical principles taught in classrooms and those applied in institutional governance raises serious concerns about moral consistency and professional integrity.

1.4 Objectives of the Study

This ethical case study seeks to:

- Examine the moral responsibilities of academic institutions as custodians of student data.
- Evaluate whether IOE acted ethically before, during, and after the data breach.
- Analyze the ethical harm experienced by affected students.
- Propose ethically grounded recommendations to prevent similar failures.

1.5 Motivation and Significance of the study

This case study is motivated by the growing reliance of Nepali academic institutions on digital systems without corresponding emphasis on ethical data governance. The IOE data breach is particularly concerning because it occurred in an institution responsible for educating future engineers and IT professionals. The incident highlights that technical knowledge alone is insufficient if ethical responsibility and institutional commitment to data protection are lacking. This study

is significant because it shifts the focus from technical explanations to ethical accountability. In Nepal, discussions around data breaches often end with identifying "what went wrong" without addressing "what should have been done morally." By centering ethical responsibility, this report contributes to a broader understanding of professional ethics in academic institutions and emphasizes the importance of moral governance in the digital age.

Chapter 2

Literature Review

2.1 Ethical Responsibility in Academic Data Stewardship

The rapid digitization of academic administration has transformed higher education institutions into major custodians of personal data. Universities routinely collect and manage sensitive information such as student identities, academic records, and contact details as a prerequisite for enrollment and participation in academic life. This role places institutions in a position of moral responsibility, requiring them to safeguard not only data integrity but also the dignity, autonomy, and trust of students. Ethical scholarship consistently emphasizes that data stewardship in such contexts is not a neutral administrative task but a moral obligation grounded in responsibility and care.

2.2 Professional Ethics Frameworks and Institutional Obligations

Professional computing ethics frameworks provide a foundational basis for evaluating institutional obligations related to data protection. The ACM Code of Ethics and the AITP Code of Ethics explicitly require computing professionals and institutions to avoid harm, respect privacy, act transparently, and accept accountability when failures occur (ACM, 2018; AITP, 2023). These principles apply not only to individual practitioners but also to organizations that design, manage, and govern information systems. In public educational institutions, where students have limited choice regarding data collection and system usage, these ethical duties are further intensified. Ethical compliance, therefore, extends beyond technical competence or legal adherence and encompasses proactive responsibility and honest communication.

2.3 Ethical Perspectives on the IOE Data Breach

Existing commentary on the IOE data breach largely documents the scale of student data exposure but places limited emphasis on ethical responsibility. While several authors describe the incident as a failure of institutional governance, the discussion often centers on operational inadequacy rather than moral accountability. (Chand, 2025a) characterizes the breach as a systemic failure within an institution expected to exemplify professional standards, highlighting the ethical contradiction between IOE's academic mission and its institutional practices. Similarly, analyses by (TrpUnfolds, 2025) point to organizational and cultural shortcomings that

reflect a broader neglect of ethical responsibility within institutional governance structures. These perspectives suggest that the breach cannot be understood solely as an isolated event, but rather as a manifestation of deeper ethical and organizational failures.

2.4 Systemic Ethical Failures in Nepal's Public Sector

Broader analyses of data breaches within Nepal's public sector reinforce this interpretation. Studies examining similar incidents consistently identify patterns of institutional negligence, inadequate preparedness, and weak accountability mechanisms. Rather than treating breaches as exceptional events, this body of literature frames them as symptoms of systemic ethical lapses, where institutions fail to recognize their moral duties toward affected individuals. Such failures raise critical ethical questions regarding diligence, foresight, and the prioritization of stakeholder welfare.

2.5 Transparency, Disclosure, and Moral Harm

Despite documenting incidents and institutional shortcomings, existing literature reveals a significant ethical gap. There is limited examination of whether affected individuals were treated as moral stakeholders deserving of timely disclosure, meaningful explanation, and harm mitigation. Ethical standards emphasize that individuals whose data is compromised have a right to be informed and supported, as withholding such information denies them agency and exposes them to further risk. The absence of sustained discussion on these obligations highlights a neglect of ethical considerations in prevailing analyses.

2.6 Power Asymmetry and Student Vulnerability

Ethical scholarship further underscores the importance of power asymmetry in educational institutions. Students are required to submit personal data as a condition of enrollment, creating an implicit trust relationship in which institutions assume a heightened duty of care. Floridi et al. (2018) argue that ethical harm in data breaches extends beyond legal or financial loss, potentially undermining personal autonomy, psychological security, and long-term trust. In this context, ethical failure is measured not only by the occurrence of a breach, but by how institutions respond to those affected.

2.7 Nepalese Legal Framework and Ethical Gaps

Nepal's legal framework, including the Electronic Transaction Act 2063 and the Privacy Act 2075, recognizes privacy as a fundamental right but provides limited ethical guidance on institutional accountability, proactive disclosure, and harm mitigation. The absence of explicit ethical enforcement mechanisms places greater

moral responsibility on institutions to self-regulate and act in accordance with professional ethical standards rather than minimal legal compliance. This gap between legal obligation and ethical responsibility is particularly significant in public academic institutions entrusted with large-scale personal data.

2.8 Identified Gaps in Existing Literature

Taken together, the existing literature highlights the need for an ethics-centered analysis of the IOE data breach. Prior discussions have largely emphasized institutional shortcomings without systematically evaluating moral responsibility, transparency, and stakeholder impact. This study addresses that gap by examining the incident through established ethical frameworks, focusing on what ethical obligations existed, how they were neglected, and what principles should guide future institutional practice. By shifting attention from operational failure to ethical accountability, this research contributes to a deeper understanding of data protection ethics within Nepal's higher education sector.

Chapter 3

Materials and Methods

This section outlines the research methodology employed to examine the ethical responsibilities of IT professionals in relation to the recent Institute of Engineering (Nepal) data breach. A qualitative research approach was adopted to capture in-depth perspectives from individuals with relevant experience and knowledge of the incident. Primary data were obtained through interviews, supported by secondary data gathered from a review of related articles and publicly available sources. The research methodology adopted for this ethical study is described as follows:

3.1 Interviews

Interviews were conducted with cybersecurity professionals, affected individuals, and peers to obtain a comprehensive understanding of the incident and firsthand perspectives. A structured set of questions was used, allowing for both formal and informal discussion formats to accommodate participants' viewpoints. Interview questions focused on themes such as duty of care, communication practices, awareness of the breach, and the perceived adequacy of institutional response.

Attempts were made to obtain official perspectives from the Institute of Engineering regarding the incident; however, no formal response was received. This absence of institutional engagement is itself ethically relevant and has been considered as part of the broader analysis of transparency and accountability. As a result, the study relied on secondary sources as the primary basis of information.

Additionally, no verifiable information could be obtained regarding the legal repercussion faced by alleged perpetrator, identified as B0xH34D Chand (2025a), as there appears to be no publicly available legal case related to the incident.

3.2 Blogs and Articles

Blogs and opinion articles were analyzed as expressions of ethical concern, public accountability, and professional reflection, rather than as technical evidence. Sources included Medium Neupane (2025) articles, a Studoc Bhattarai (2025) case study, and a blog published by TRP Unfolds TrpUnfolds (2025), which provided insights into student responses, and professional opinions related to the breach.

3.3 Social Media Analysis

Public reactions to the breach were examined through content published on social media platforms. This included articles shared by reputable sources such as Techpana on Facebook Techpana (2025), individual discussions on Reddit, and professional commentary from IT lawyersKoirala (2025a) and cybersecurity experts Chand (2025b)on LinkedIn. These sources were analyzed to assess public sentiment and the concerns of individuals whose data were alleged to have been exposed on the dark web.Since the analyzed content was publicly accessible, its use aligns with ethical research norms; however, care was taken to respect individual privacy and avoid amplifying harm.

3.4 Ethical Considerations in Methodology

This study adheres to ethical research principles by prioritizing harm minimization, accuracy, and respect for individuals affected by the breach. No private or confidential data were accessed. Publicly available information was used cautiously to avoid amplifying harm or misinformation. The analysis deliberately emphasizes institutional responsibility over individual blame, aligning with ethical standards for fairness, accountability, and responsible scholarship.

3.5 Summary of Methodological Ethics

All methods were designed to ensure ethical compliance, minimize harm, and respect participant autonomy. Data collection emphasized stakeholder perspectives, transparency, and confidentiality, aligning with professional codes of ethics in computing.

Chapter 4

Results and Discussion

The analysis of interview responses, reviewed articles, and publicly available sources revealed several recurring themes related to the ethical responsibilities of IT professionals in the context of the data breach. These findings are presented thematically to reflect common patterns across data sources.

4.1 Ethical Responsibility of IT professionals

Interviews of IT professionals and students, articles, blogs and social media posts all lead to the same story. The findings suggest that ethical obligations of due care and harm prevention were not sufficiently institutionalized, resulting in preventable ethical harm to students.

Although the breach was clearly not intended to occur lack of prior security audits, lack of strong enforced lawsKoirala (2025b) along with security reports of the system was found to be generated using free and automated tools without employing real effort or workforce in website security Neupane (2025), use of outdated packages and security practices Chand (2025a) further made it easy to issue to be controlled before it was too late.

4.2 Transparency from the institution and awareness of the incident

Interview, survey and articles here all reveal different scenarios as interview with cybersecurity researcher and professional at IOE reveal that no effort was made to make students and affected victims aware about the breach and no remedial steps were taken with interview session resulting in a conclusion that if the attacks were to happen today it would result in the same security failure whereas some articles do mention the efforts like enabling multifactor authentication, security audit and contacting authorities Bhattarai (2025). Few interviews reveal that the victims only were made aware of the incident after reading articles and social media posts from Techpana Techpana (2025), and Reddit.

4.3 Impact on Public trust and relations

The survey revealed that victims now find it difficult to trust their sensitive data with institutions. Particularly :

- Some victims expressed that it is reasonable for such a large institution to be susceptible to such attacks, what they did not appreciate is how easily such a large institution can be breached without the institution's knowledge and leaked across the dark web.
- Victims also find it unsatisfactory of how there is lack of coverage and awareness among the public of this incident and there was no coverage or legal actions taken against the perpetrator.
- Cybersecurity professionals also find it embarrassing that an institution of such a massive scale as IOE would succumb to such attacks and calls it a systemic failure between what is taught in their courses and actual implementationChand (2025a).

The findings of this study reveal notable ethical shortcomings in both professional conduct and institutional practices related to the data breach. Although the breach was not intentional, evidence from interviews and secondary sources indicates inadequate adherence to ethical responsibilities, including insufficient security audits, outdated security practices, and an overreliance on automated tools. Such lapses reflect a failure to exercise due diligence, a fundamental ethical obligation of IT professionals entrusted with sensitive data.

The results also emphasize the influence of institutional governance and regulatory enforcement on ethical behavior. Weak cybersecurity policies and limited enforcement mechanisms appear to have contributed to systemic vulnerabilities, underscoring that ethical responsibility extends beyond individual professionals to the institution as a whole.

A lack of transparency further compounded the ethical concerns. Many affected individuals were not formally informed of the breach and instead learned of it through media and social platforms. While some reports suggest remedial actions were undertaken, inconsistent communication undermined ethical principles of accountability and openness.

Finally, the breach has negatively impacted public trust, with victims expressing reduced confidence in institutional data handling. The absence of visible accountability and limited public discourse intensified this loss of trust. Concerns raised by cybersecurity professionals regarding the disparity between academic instruction and practical implementation point to a broader ethical and systemic failure. Overall, the findings highlight the need for stronger ethical commitment, transparency, and accountability in institutional cybersecurity practices.

Chapter 5

Conclusion and Recommendations

Although the breach has negatively impacted IOE's public trust, institutional reputation, and highlighted gaps in technical and ethical responsibility, this study identifies several measures that can strengthen ethical responsibility and data protection practices within academic institutions.

5.1 Immediate Remediation

- Notify affected students and stakeholders, providing clear guidance on potential risks and recommended protective measures.

5.2 Structural Reforms

- **Leverage Student Expertise:** Encourage and reward students for responsibly identifying and reporting vulnerabilities in IOE's systems.

5.3 Cultural Shift

- **Transparency and Accountability:** Publicly release breach post-mortems and updates on remediation progress to rebuild trust.
- **Policy Advocacy:** Advocate for the enactment and enforcement of Nepal's long-pending data protection laws.

The recent data breach incident at the Institute of Engineering highlights not only the institution's vulnerability to cybersecurity attacks but also reveals broader systemic weaknesses in the implementation of cybersecurity practices within Nepalese educational institutions. Given that cybersecurity is taught at an advanced academic level, this incident raises serious concerns regarding the practical application of such knowledge. This event should serve as a critical turning point for the Institute, emphasizing the need for stronger technical safeguards and fostering a culture of cybersecurity awareness among both students and staff.

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Appendix

A.1 Permission Letter to conduct ethical study

Kathmandu University
School of Engineering

To whom it may concern,

Subject : Request to conduct an Academic Study

Dear Sir,

This letter is to request your formal permission to allow the students of Computer Science and Engineering from Kathmandu University to conduct an academic case study on the recent IOE data breach.The study will be focused on the sequence of events that occurred that day, the decision made by the institution and the response to the general public as well as in strengthening the system against such attacks in the future.

The purpose of this study is strictly academic and educational. It aims to analyze the sequence of events, organizational vulnerabilities, crisis-management decisions, communication with stakeholders, and post-incident improvements, with a focus on ethical responsibilities, user privacy, and professional conduct in cybersecurity practice. **No sensitive, confidential, or proprietary information obtained from IOE will be disclosed outside the classroom**, and any data shared with us will be handled in line with research ethics and relevant institutional guidelines.

If permitted, the study team would like to:

- Review publicly available information and official communications related to the breach and its handling.
- Request short, pre-arranged interviews or written inputs from designated administrative and/or technical personnel involved in managing or responding to the incident.

All findings will be used solely for internal evaluation, and academic reporting within Kathmandu University, with no commercial use or public distribution.

The cooperation of IOE in this academic case study will significantly contribute to developing more informed, ethics-aware IT professionals and will also highlight IOE's commitment to transparency, learning, and continuous improvement in cybersecurity and data protection. Thus, we kindly request your approval to proceed with this study and would be grateful if you could also inform us of any specific conditions, limitations, or protocols that you would like us to follow.

Thank you for considering this request.

Best Regards,

Er. Pankaj Raj Dawadi, PhD
Acting Head
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Figure 5.1: Permission Letter from Department

A.2 Interview Video Link

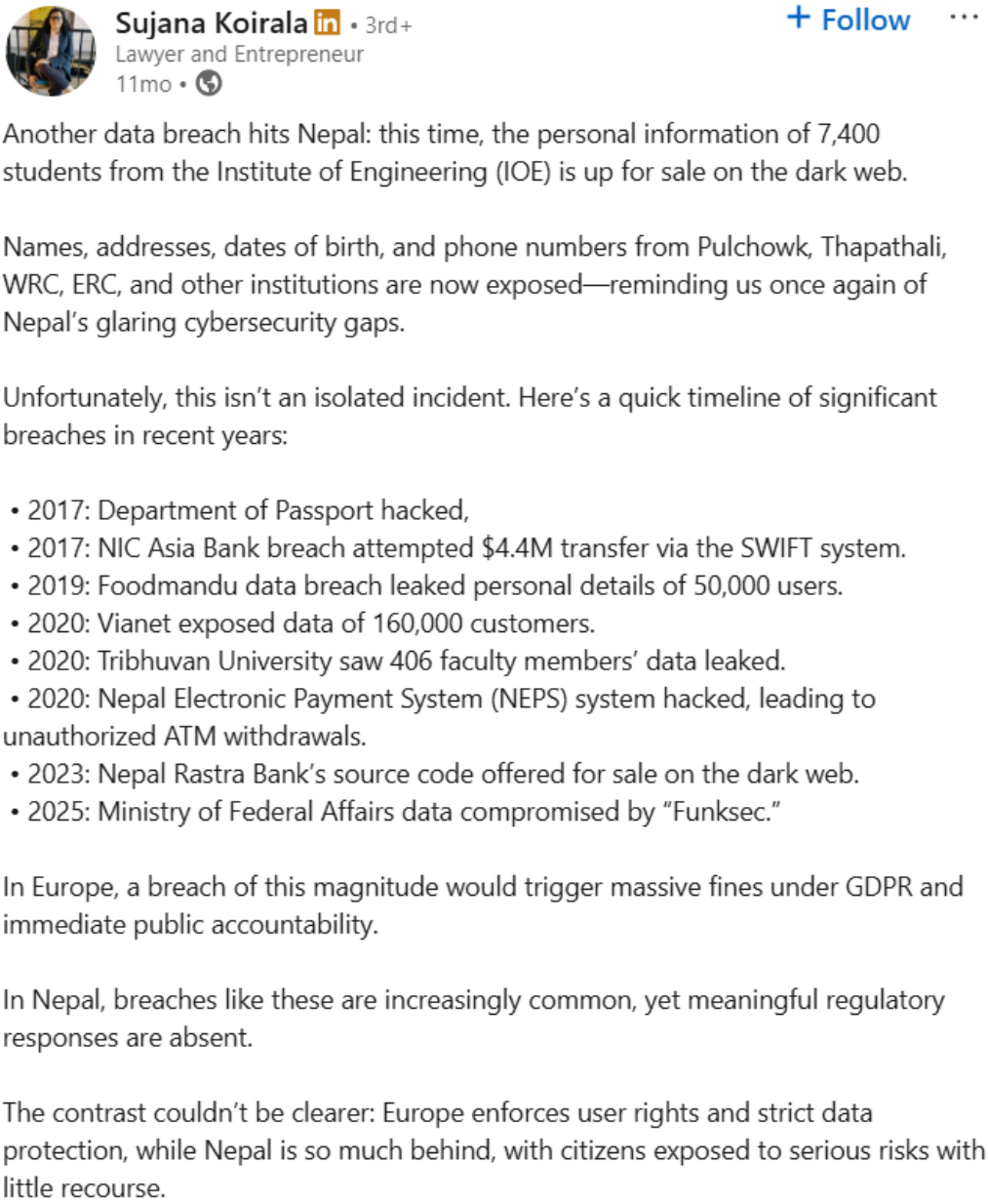
Visit the google drive **link** for more info

A.3 TechPana's Facebook Post

Figure 5.2: TechPana FB Post

Visit **link** for more info

A.4 Professional's take on the event



Sujana Koirala • 3rd+
Lawyer and Entrepreneur
11mo •

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Another data breach hits Nepal: this time, the personal information of 7,400 students from the Institute of Engineering (IOE) is up for sale on the dark web.

Names, addresses, dates of birth, and phone numbers from Pulchowk, Thapathali, WRC, ERC, and other institutions are now exposed—reminding us once again of Nepal's glaring cybersecurity gaps.

Unfortunately, this isn't an isolated incident. Here's a quick timeline of significant breaches in recent years:

- 2017: Department of Passport hacked,
- 2017: NIC Asia Bank breach attempted $4.4M transfer via the SWIFT system.
- 2019: Foodmandu data breach leaked personal details of 50,000 users.
- 2020: Vianet exposed data of 160,000 customers.
- 2020: Tribhuvan University saw 406 faculty members' data leaked.
- 2020: Nepal Electronic Payment System (NEPS) system hacked, leading to unauthorized ATM withdrawals.
- 2023: Nepal Rastra Bank's source code offered for sale on the dark web.
- 2025: Ministry of Federal Affairs data compromised by "Funksec."

In Europe, a breach of this magnitude would trigger massive fines under GDPR and immediate public accountability.

In Nepal, breaches like these are increasingly common, yet meaningful regulatory responses are absent.

The contrast couldn't be clearer: Europe enforces user rights and strict data protection, while Nepal is so much behind, with citizens exposed to serious risks with little recourse.

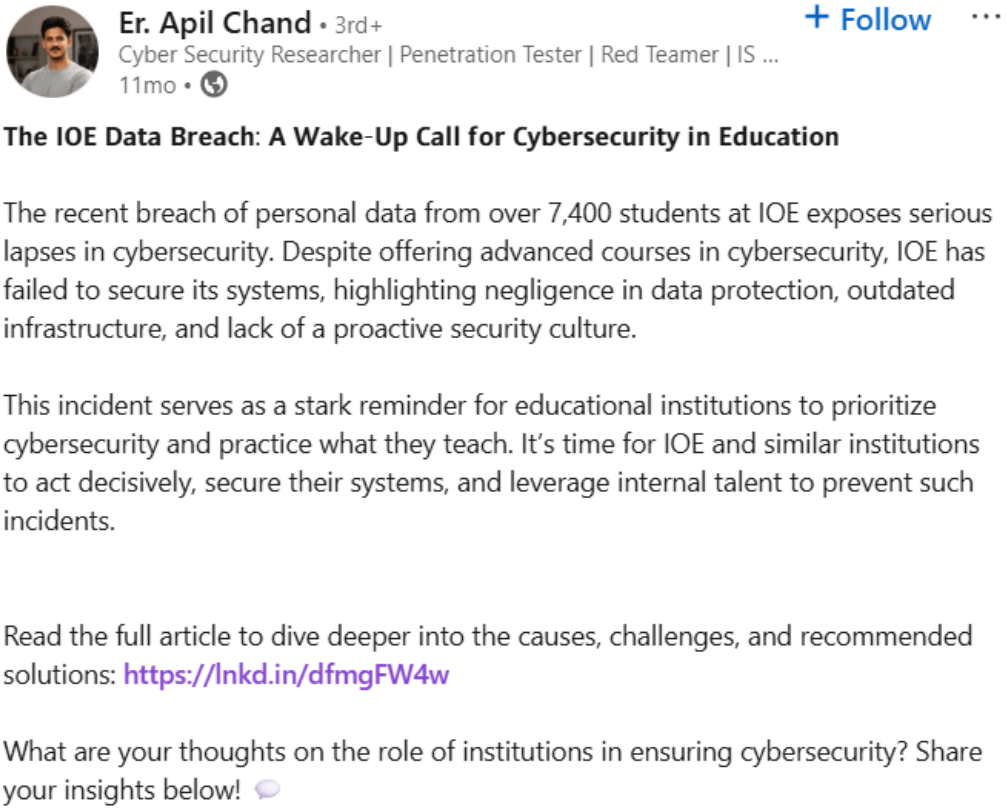
Figure 5.3: LinkedIn Post on the event

Visit **link** for more info

A.5 Cybersecurity specialist's post on the incident

Figure 5.4: LinkedIn Post on the event

Visit **link** for more info.



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The IOE Data Breach: A Wake-Up Call for Cybersecurity in Education

The recent breach of personal data from over 7,400 students at IOE exposes serious lapses in cybersecurity. Despite offering advanced courses in cybersecurity, IOE has failed to secure its systems, highlighting negligence in data protection, outdated infrastructure, and lack of a proactive security culture.

This incident serves as a stark reminder for educational institutions to prioritize cybersecurity and practice what they teach. It's time for IOE and similar institutions to act decisively, secure their systems, and leverage internal talent to prevent such incidents.

Read the full article to dive deeper into the causes, challenges, and recommended solutions: https://lnkd.in/dfmgFW4w

What are your thoughts on the role of institutions in ensuring cybersecurity? Share your insights below!

Figure 5.5: LinkedIn Post on the event

Visit **link** for more info.

A.6 Reddit post covering the event

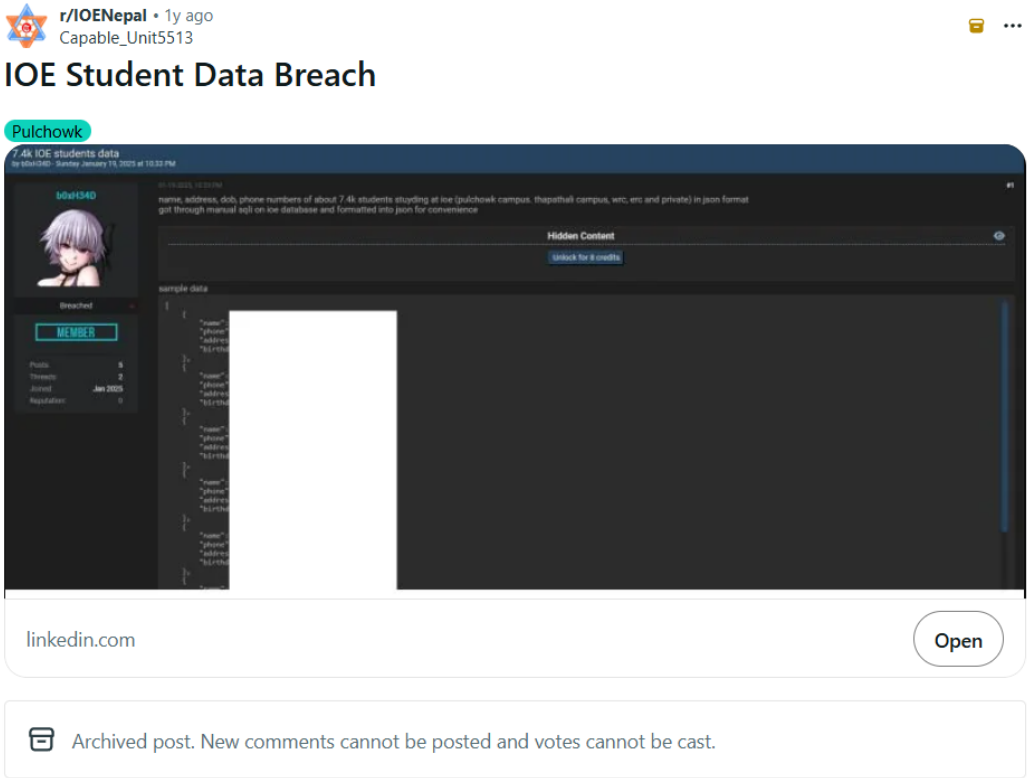

Figure 5.6: Reddit Post

Visit **link** for more info.